



The remains of Hadrian's Wall in northern England. The central portion of the wall occupies a high position that vastly enhances its defensive value.

Gulf near modern Basra, Iraq, where he is said to have remarked that, had he been younger, he might have pressed on to India. The newly conquered territories were organized as the provinces of **Mesopotamia** and **Assyria**, but they were already in revolt when Trajan returned home in 117. The Parthians rejected Trajan's **puppet king Parthamaspatēs**, and by the time Trajan died in August 117 almost all of his gains in the east had been lost. On his death-bed Trajan adopted Publius Aelius Hadrianus (**Hadrian**), the governor of Syria, effectively appointing Hadrian as his successor.

In 109, Trajan appointed the historian **Pliny the Younger** (61–c. 112) as his personal representative to govern **Bithynia-Pontus** on the Black Sea coast of Anatolia. This was a controversial move, as Bithynia-Pontus was theoretically a senatorial province. The provinces of the empire had been divided between the emperor and the senate at the accession of Augustus in 27 BCE, with the emperor receiving only the provinces that held legionary garrisons. This division of the provinces persisted into the time of Trajan. Pliny stayed in Bithynia-Pontus for at least two years, trying to sort out the finances of the main cities, which had fallen into confusion. His letters to Trajan are an invaluable insight into the imperial government of the time.

TRAJAN'S SUCCESSOR HADRIAN (r. 117–135) rejected his predecessor's policy of expansion and concentrated on better defense of the **imperial frontiers**. In 122, Hadrian visited Britain, where there had been frontier troubles. He ordered the building of a huge barrier from the Solway Firth in the west to the Tyne River in the east. It took governor **Aulus Platorius Nepos** two years to complete **Hadrian's Wall** (part in stone, and part in turf), which ran 76 Roman miles (113 km), and was equipped with a series of forts and milecastles for its garrison. Hadrian's Wall acted as the northern frontier line of Roman Britain for the next 40 years.

The **Parthian kingdom** was left in some confusion by the campaigns of Trajan. His puppet king, Parthamaspatēs, was expelled in 117, but the Parthian kingdom then seems to have been divided between **Vologeses**

985 THE NUMBER OF VILLAGES RAZED DURING THE BAR-KOCHBA REVOLT

III (r. 105–147) who ruled the eastern portion, and **Osroes** (r. 117–129) then **Mithridates IV** (r. 129–140) in the west. There was no further conflict between Parthia and Rome for the time being.

In India, the **Kushan empire** expanded enormously under **Kanishka** (127–140), who conquered Magadha and campaigned against the Chinese in Central Asia; his inscriptions

are found from the Oxus river in Afghanistan to as far south as Varanasi and Sanchi. He was a strong patron of Buddhism and presided over the **fourth Buddhist Council**, as well as building a great stupa at his capital Purushapura (Peshawar).

Hadrian's ban on circumcision, his plan to turn Jerusalem into the Roman town of Aelia Capitolina, and his intent to ban Jewish religious practices in Jerusalem caused a furious **revolt in Jerusalem** in 132, as religious Jews rose up against religious reforms. Led by **Shimon Bar Kochba**, the rebels had early successes against Rome. They set up the beginnings of an independent government and minted their own coins. In response, Hadrian summoned **Julius Severus**, the governor of Britain, to conduct a war against the rebels. Severus commanded an army formed of detachments from 12 legions. The rebels had no large towns under their control, and so adopted **guerrilla warfare** while still attempting to defend the smaller forts they held. In 135, the rebel's last main stronghold at **Bethar** was captured amid great

slaughter, after which the revolt petered out. Hadrian proceeded with his plan to **outlaw Judaism** in Palestine, and many of the Jews who had survived the rebellion fled abroad.



Treasured goblet
This beautiful vase was found in Kapisa (Bagram) near Kabul, which was the Kushan summer capital in the 1st century.

HADRIAN (76–138)

Hadrian came from a Spanish background and was the adopted son of his predecessor, Trajan. He was mocked by some for his grecophile tendencies, and was the first emperor to sport a beard—a Greek fashion. Hadrian was the first emperor to travel widely throughout the Roman empire, giving him first-hand knowledge of the provinces, from Britain to North Africa.

